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Coming Out of the Coffin: Life-Self and Death-Self in *Six Feet Under*

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This article discusses how the dominant approach to life and death as binary structures in American society influences the social construction of the self. Through the analysis of the television series Six Feet Under, we identify two types of selves: a “life-self” and a “death-self.” Questioning this binary, we offer the concept of “transitory movements” to suggest instead that a “waltzing” movement between life and death endows the self with meaning and stands at the core of the self-work of agents. Finally, we discuss the implications of our analysis for scholarship on the self and on the sociology of death.

Central to the sociology of death is the assumption that modern society buries death “six feet under.” The widespread explanation for this phenomenon is that death undermines the logic of modernity, which celebrates mastery, progress, and recovery. Sociology—as a modern project—is described in the scholarship as distancing itself from death and addressing predominately life-related issues (Lee 2002; Mellor and Shilling 1993). As a result, life and death are binary opposites both in modern society and in the social sciences. Given this background, it may not be surprising that the name given to death studies within the discipline—the sociology of death—reflects this binary.

The present study emerges from our reflections on this relationship between life and death as it is played out in the HBO television series *Six Feet Under*. The series, described by its creator Alan Ball as an “existential soap opera” (Schardl 2003), focuses on the Fisher family and the Los Angeles funeral home that they manage. This densely symbolic series hurls death provocatively into the viewer’s face, each episode consciously serving as a “memento mori” for its audience.¹ Consequently,

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death is starkly present within the life-world of the series, challenging the strict binary between life and death. The blurring of these boundaries evokes the idea that the living can be more lifeless than the physically deceased and that the departed can be livelier than the living.

In this article, we attempt to open up the “sociology of death” to a “sociology of life and death” by exploring the intersection between life, death, and the self. Several central questions pave our way: (1) What are the dynamics of life and death in *Six Feet Under*? (2) What do these dynamics reveal about American cultural attitudes toward life and death? (3) How do the characters express life and death? Do they use life and death to describe themselves (self-concept)? Can we recognize discourses, sites, and practices that maintain this self-concept?²

At this point, we already want to emphasize that the self-concept of the characters in this television text maintains daily interactions with existential issues relating to life and to death. This, in turn, informs us that life and death are likely to routinely preoccupy ordinary people and not only in the wake of intrusive illness (Charmaz 1991). Moreover, this self-concept, as we shall argue, emerges from a phenomenological movement of subjects between two fixed cultural categories. According to this movement, the self is not merely a product of internalizing the perspective of others (significant or generalized) or of interacting with significant others (Cooley [1902] 1983; Mead 1934) but also emerges from the interaction between specific cultural categories.

This article progresses in five stages. First, we review the scholarly literature on life, death, and the self. Second, we outline the methodology used to formulate our central concepts: the “life-self,” the “death-self,” and the “transitory movements.” Third, we analyze the central characters in the series in terms of the life-self and death-self. Fourth, we characterize the relationship between life, death, and the self through the concept of transitory movements. Finally, we examine the relationship between the sociology of death and sociology of self.

LIFE, DEATH, AND THE SELF

Metonymically, the title of the series encapsulates modern-day attitudes toward life and death. Specifically, the phrase “six feet under” relates to the traditional European folk belief that the dead should be buried at a sufficient distance beneath the ground so as to separate them from the living, lest the former harm or haunt the latter.³ Much as this folk belief suggests, American culture constructs the concepts of life and death as binary opposites that position the transgression of boundaries between them as pollution. As many scholars have noted (Kubler-Ross 1969; Lee 2002; Mellor 1993), contemporary American culture worships youth and progress while evading, ignoring, and denying death.

In much of the sociology of death literature, the modern attitude toward death is compared with a romanticized picture of premodern, traditional societies. As Lee (2002:100) suggests, there is disenchantment from death and “symbolic aridity” surrounding it in modernity as opposed to enchanted rituals and “symbolic wetness”

surrounding death in the premodern. Our analysis of the sociological scholarship on death reveals five strategies that modern societies employ to “kill death” (Seale 1998:3). First, death is made absent from the public sphere, and its presence is narrowed to the private sphere. Second, modern society denies death through its obsessive cultivation of the body, stressing vitality, fitness, health, and youth. Third, scholars such as Seale (1998) point out how modern societies transform death into a potentially life-affirming event. Through psychological paradigms, death is cast as an opportunity for personal growth and life enhancement. Fourth, it is argued that modern technology produces a narrative of human control over death through organ transplants, cosmetic surgery, and resuscitation machines (Lock 2001). Finally, scholars assert that the media is a powerful vehicle for maintaining the strict boundaries between life and death that enable the denial of the latter (Laderman 2000). The media serves as a site of the “pornography of death,” as Gorer (1955) suggests.

The same argument has even been explicitly made regarding sociological inquiry into death. As Mellor (1993) and Mellor and Shilling (1993:41) note, sociologists tend to explore life-issues more often than death-issues, and they tend to explore both as separate domains. In other words, when sociological inquiry does focus on death, it is in an either-or fashion, so that death is regarded as a field of inquiry distinct from life.

One purpose of this article is to respond to Mellor’s (1993) call for the expansion of this narrow focus: “The sociology of death . . . must integrate life and death into its theoretical programme” (p. 27). We hope to take steps toward opening up the “sociology of death” to the “sociology of life and death” by exploring the intersection between life, death, and the self.

We argue that the same binary logic that characterizes both modernity and the sociology of death is also expressed in the self-identity types that are offered to modern American subjects. Reflecting the modern dualist approach, both the theoretical and the empirical literature on the self regards it as firmly grounded in life-related notions such as vitality, productivity, and health. Normative measures of the good self are based on life-related characteristics such as activity, liveliness, personal growth, and development. All things connected with death, such as melancholy, bereavement, aggression, and destructive impulses, are interpreted as signs of pathology of the self (Rose 1996).

Lee (2002) notes that the study of death is not merely a means to inquire into our mortality but “a reflection on the way we construct our self-identities. Death makes us more aware of how these identities are constructed, reified, and eventually deconstructed” (106). In light of this idea, we shall attempt in the following to challenge the dichotomous construction of the self through a character analysis of the selves of the main characters in *Six Feet Under*.

METHODS AND DATA

Launched in the fall of 2001 on the U.S. cable television station HBO, *Six Feet Under* continued for five seasons before its end in 2005. In this sociological analysis of the

series, we apply content analysis to the visual medium and to the spoken dialogue of the first and second seasons.⁴ We see television as an important social and aesthetic force that serves as a powerful instrument for disseminating and legitimating culture and for regulating how persons and things are represented and valued. Television reflects and reiterates society's most widely and deeply held values and beliefs and influences a society's sense of who we are and who we should be. In other words, television can serve as a site for constructing the self (Illouz 2003).

We have followed the analytic process of grounded theory outlined by Glaser and Strauss (1967). Although they formulated this process to analyze ethnographic data, we find it applicable to media texts as well. Strauss (1978) suggests a number of stages for articulating theoretical arguments: open coding, axial coding, selective coding, identifying core categories, and creating a theoretical setting.⁵

This inductive methodology produced the central categories of our analysis: the life-self and the death-self. To clarify how these concepts work, we elaborate upon their emergence. We initiated the analysis to understand the symbolic representations of life and death in this popular television text and the dynamics between them. In addition, we wanted to examine how the central characters in the series experience issues related to life and death in their everyday life. In terms of symbolic interaction theory (Blumer 1969), we wondered how these symbolic representations are expressed in a character's self-concept and in the interactions that they conduct in respect to these representations. With these objectives in hand, we determined that symbolic representations of life and death occupy a central place in the discourse universe of the characters. Furthermore, the characters interpret their reality in these terms. They perceive themselves and their significant others as death types or life types. Their identity-work includes trying to associate themselves with persons and places they categorize as life and distancing themselves from what they perceive as spaces of death. As a result, we identified two ideal types of self: the life-self and the death-self. In the next step we followed Glaser and Strauss's (1967) suggestion to discern the relationship between these analytic categories. Our findings reveal that there is not a dichotomous relationship between these self-types but a constant movement between them, which in turn constitutes meaning. This led us to conceptualize the relationship in terms of "transitory movements." We now turn to a detailed outline of our central concepts, the life-self and the death-self.

THE LIFE-SELF AND THE DEATH-SELF

The characters seem to have been deliberately designed to represent two opposite types of selves: a life-self and a death-self. The Fisher family includes four living members: the widowed mother, Ruth; the eldest son, Nate; the middle son, David; and the teenage daughter, Claire. Two of the Fishers perform each of the two roles. Nate and Claire personify the life-self, a self that is unchained, liberated, and sexual. It does not conform to societal dictates but follows an original path based on curiosity, adventurousness (travel, art), and openness toward experimentation

(drugs, sex). The life-self is not afraid to live, have fun, express emotions openly, experience intimacy, or tell the truth. The language of the life-self is peppered with curse words (*shit, fuck*) and with slang words (*gonna, wanna, gotta*).⁶

Ruth and David portray the death-self. This ideal type is frozen, sexually repressed, controlling, and uptight. It represents a Victorian type in terms of the moral standards by which they abide: self-sacrifice, modesty, piety, and even a hint of self-righteousness (Illouz 2003). The death-self is always uncomfortable, anxious, scared, suffocated, and hiding. These characters play by the rules, fulfilling their socially prescribed roles as dutiful wife and observant son. They attend church regularly, never use foul language, and sacrifice their own dreams (of seeing the pyramids and going to law school, respectively) for the good of their family.⁷

Following the sociological scholarship on the self, which posits that cultural scripts, language, sites, and techniques maintain the self (Rose 1996), we add that symbols also maintain the life-self and the death-self. Each self is symbolically associated with a particular bodily organ (choked throat/open heart), object (burial coffin/ motorcycle), and city (Los Angeles/Seattle). Moreover, each ideal type is represented in the series through modes of dress. The death-self prefers conservative, bland-colored skirts (Ruth) or starched black suits with a tie (David); the life-self wears jeans and clothes that are casual, comfortable, and colorful (Nate and Claire). Finally, these selves are metonymically represented by the spaces they occupy. The life-self is most often outside the home (Claire at school and Nate at his girlfriend Brenda's home) or in the upper, more-illuminated floors of the home. The death-self is most often portrayed inside the home (David buried in his work in the dim basement and Ruth trapped in the shadows of her dark, confining kitchen).

Death-Self: Ruth and David

Ruth

The most central theme in Ruth's self is that of relinquishing her past self and adopting a new self. Ruth wants to reinvent herself and to have a private life after her husband's death. She sees her past (old self) as a death, expressed in her exclusive focus on others (her grandmother, husband, children); her dependency on others (emotional and financial); her secrets; her lack of intimacy with her husband and children; and her planned, conventional life without adventures.

Informed by symbolic interaction theory (Blumer 1969), we offer that Ruth's death-self is largely constituted by how her significant others perceive her. Ruth's family sees her as a "control freak" (Nate [1/1/1]), "lonely" (Nate [1/1/3]), "weird" (David [1/13/2]), and "just so sad" (Claire [1/5/2]).⁸ Ruth's death-self scheme is also expressed in her self-image. Ruth perceives herself as a victim, a "sacrificed self," as someone whose life was dictated to her instead of chosen. As a result, she describes feeling as if she were "trapped in a cage" (Ball and Poul 2003:22). Her entrapment is communicated to the viewer through camera angles that depict her as a small, frozen figure in her large, gloomy kitchen where the walls seem to be closing in.

Ruth attempts to acquire a life-self through career independence, romance, and intimacy with her children. She manages the first by leaving her secondary role, “answering dead calls” for the family funeral home, and taking a part-time job at a flower shop. Ruth achieves romance and passion by revealing her illicit love affair to her children, followed by a fiery relationship with her Russian employer. In this relationship, Ruth insists on distancing herself from her old, death-role-identity (dutiful wife) and adopts a new, independent, life-role-identity (lover). She tells Nikolai, “I will be your friend and your lover but I will never be your wife. I spent the first half of my life doing that. I don’t need to do it again” (1/13/3).

As for intimacy with her three children, Ruth tells them, “All I want is for us not to be strangers. I want some intimacy. (Pleading) Give me intimacy! Won’t any of you have intimacy with me?!?” (2/5/2). She encourages her homosexual son David to come out to her and to expose his secrets for the sake of creating an honest relationship based on truth. She tries to facilitate communication with Claire by questioning her about her behavior and accompanying her to sessions with the school psychologist.

Ruth attempts to acquire her new life-self by using three tools: sites, language, and interactions. The first site of self-reinvention that Ruth uses might be the most accessible one authored in the postmodern West: a self-help seminar and the unique “self-marathon” (Cushman 1995) that it involves. During her first session, the seminar leader diagnoses Ruth’s death-self, telling her that she has been “a guest in her own house” who “tiptoes around herself like she’s afraid of waking someone up.” Ruth is urged to open herself up to a new life-self: “Ruth, you have to get out of bed, open the windows, and let some light into your house!” (2/3/1). Other sites include Ruth’s adventure at the racetrack where she “felt so good, like I was living someone else’s life. . . . then I started to lose, and then I started to feel like me again” (1/3/2), and the flower shop where she realizes that she “can’t remember being surrounded by so much happiness. . . . I’m used to people crying and being exhausted” (1/7/2).

Regarding language, Ruth acquires a life-self through speaking the language of life. In the life-affirming seminar she attends, “The Plan,” Ruth learns to conceptualize life through architectural metaphors—to “design” and “draft a clear blueprint” for her life. In her everyday life, Ruth uses life-words and phrases as though she believes that if she repeats them enough, almost ritually, the language itself might magically constitute her longed-for life-self. For instance, she reminds her daughter, but also herself, “We have to eat, Claire. We didn’t die!” (1/1/1) and tells her eldest son, Nate, “I don’t want to be careful. I want to feel alive!” (1/3/2).

Through her relationships with significant others, Ruth acquires her self in a way that illustrates the symbolic interaction theory emphasis on interactions as constitutive of selves. In response to Ruth’s desire to escape her death-world, she finds a job in the life-world of the flower shop, where she embarks on a love affair with Nikolai. Nikolai fulfills an identity-role of passion, sexuality, and spontaneity that offsets Ruth’s death-self. He recognizes the frozen habitus of the Fisher family and compares it with the passionate Russians of his community:

You should come to my neighborhood. All Russian. You would love it. People with passion, full of life. Not like your family. . . . Russians speak from here [points to chest], from the heart, with their souls, not like Fisher, like from here [points to throat] like a little mouse goes [makes squeak noises]. Not like that.

Encouraging her to take action to become more alive rather than meekly verbalize her intentions, Nikolai tells her that she is “the kind of woman who needs a good lover. . . . Because you’re so scared of feeling. You are scared of your own heart. (He stands up.) You should have a man who can touch you there (points to her heart), who sees your beauty” (1/8/1). In response, Ruth comes out of herself; taking the romantic lead, she kisses him passionately and makes spontaneous love to him.

David

David, the middle Fisher son, is thirty-two years old and lives in an apartment attached to his parents’ home. A closeted homosexual who wrestles with his sexual identity, David experiences his self as a victim and as one who has sacrificed his life for the good of his family. He feels as though he has forfeited his dreams in order to continue the family business and that his life has been wasted: “What did I do with my life. . . . other kids my age were going to frat parties. I was draining corpses and refashioning severed ears out of wax” (1/1/3). David perceives himself as trapped in the role of the “good son,” because Nate has already taken the role of the “prodigal son.” David expresses his regret over sacrificing his life, saying to his lover, Keith: “It’s like I don’t exist, like me leaving law school meant nothing” (1/3/1).

David’s significant others see him as uptight, rigid, bitter, pretentious, overly dramatic, self-righteous, critical, rational, bureaucratic, and a control freak. In the family business David is perceived as emotionally rigid and is accordingly given the responsibility of embalming the corpses of babies and children. He is seen as an untalented, square-minded perfectionist, as his father’s ghost points out to him: “You’re the worst (embalmer) we’ve got. . . . go reorganize some files or develop a new bookkeeping system” (1/1/3). Aware that his family perceives him as deathly pale both physically and emotionally, he petulantly accuses his mother:

It’s like you decided you should know who I am, like you’re willing to see me the way you make yourself look at something horrible, like a corpse, because it’s your job, your duty. It revolts you, but you make yourself bare [*sic*] it. (1/13/3)

Indeed, if interactions with others construct the self, then it is telling that even the ghosts of the corpses that David embalms identify his grave nature as making him more “dead” than they are. The ghost of Paco, a young murdered gang member, for instance, notices that in his black suit in his coffin he looks like David. The lively Paco taunts David about his deathliness (“Do you ever see sunlight? Or you gotta avoid it?” [1/4/2]) and urges him to fight, be active, and take the initiative or, in Paco’s words, to “live his life like a man.” From his side, David communicates with these ghosts naturally and comfortably, confiding in them more openly than he does in the living.

David also expresses his identity struggle through his interactions with life-selves who are among the living, such as Nate and Keith. Pointing out David's deathliness, Nate encourages his brother to live: "Don't blame me if you're not living the life you want. That is nobody's fault but your own" (1/1/4). It is when interacting with life-selves that David realizes just how morbid he is. Rejecting the adventurous sexual proposition of a young lover, David apologizes for his inhibition, saying "I'm a serious guy. I bury people for a living" (1/9/3). To Nate, David acknowledges his boring character, saying, "Everything I own looks alike" (1/2/1).

The central theme in David's identity is his struggle to come to terms with his sexuality. In constant battle with his desires and attractions, David allows his secrets to shadow his daily life, serially coming out of the closet and going back in. David's reluctance to reveal his identity affects his relationship with the openly "out" Keith. Keith urges David to come out and is disappointed when David becomes a deacon at his church—a position that requires him to hide his sexual identity. He accuses David of taking "one step forward, now you wanna take a giant leap backwards into the hands of the enemy!" (1/5/2).

As the central theme of his character in the first season of the series, David's sexual identity is inextricably linked to his death-self. In contrast to the multiple sites, words, and practices through which his mother's self is constituted, David's identity process closely fits the central cultural script of the sociology of the closet (Rust 1993). David is preoccupied with transforming his self in one direction; namely, David thinks that if he can just come out of the closet, then he can learn to live.

Life-Self: Nate and Claire

Nate

The most central characteristic of Nate's self—as vividly presented to the viewer—is the identity-role of life in the family. His siblings interpret Nate's leaving home in his late teens as an act of vitality and self-preservation. From childhood, Nate was always the son who was unable to tolerate the presence of the corpses in the funeral home, as his brother reminds him: "You can't even stand to be in the same room with a dead body" (1/3/1). If David is the "antiseptic" type, a "control-freak," and spoilsport, Nate has been socialized to construct an opposite self: open, sexual, forthcoming with his emotions, a "heartbreaker" who is not ashamed of anything and critical of his family's secretive and suffocated lives. He challenges David, for example, to think about why death, and his own inner self, has to be kept so protected: "Why does it have to be such a secret? It's nothing to be ashamed of" (1/1/4).

The differences between the brothers are represented for the viewer most intensely in two cases: the father's funeral and the styles of grieving that they exhibit in interactions with the mourners at the funeral home. In a scene in the pilot episode, Nate symbolically comments on David's artificial handling of their father's funeral. Picking up a handful of dirt with his bare hands and throwing it on their father's grave instead of using the closed salt shaker that has been handed to him, Nate exclaims: "I refuse to sanitize this anymore." David replies: "This is how it's done." Nate goes on:

This stupid saltshaker. . . . What is this hermetically sealed box? This phony Astroturf around the grave? Jesus, David, it's like surgery. Clean, antiseptic, business. He was our father! You can pump him full of chemicals, you can put makeup on him, and you can prop him up in the slumber room, but the fact remains that the only father we're ever going to have is gone. . . . and you can't really accept it without getting your hands dirty. (1/1/4)

The brothers' divergent ideas about grief management further elucidate their relative positioning between life- and death-selves. While David allows that mourners may "prefer to grieve in private" (1/1/3), as he hands them tissues and leads them behind a curtain to cry, Nate believes that grief should be emotionally messy and not clean and orderly. He hugs mourners, holds their hands, cries with them, and allows them to "spill out" their grief.

Nate spends a lot of his time running, both physically and metaphorically. Running serves as a symbolic commentary on Nate when his family and friends recognize it as an anchor of his identity. His father's ghost welcomes him home, sarcastically remarking, "Well, well, the prodigal son returns. This is what you've been running away from your whole life, buddy boy. . . . And you thought you'd escape. Well, guess what? Nobody escapes!" (1/1/1). David uses the running metaphor to accuse his brother of shirking his family responsibilities: "You ran away from it and you left it all for me" (1/1/3).

Nate's female love interests use a similar logic when they confront him about his running away from the commitment to a monogamous relationship. It seems as though running has become ingrained in his reflexes when Nate's automatic response to hearing that he has been diagnosed with a life-threatening brain disorder is to go running, despite his doctor's warning not to.

Nate, who links his running to another theme in his identity, temporariness, confesses to Claire how this rootlessness has shaped his life:

I live in a shitty apartment, which was supposed to be temporary. I work at a job, which was also supposed to be temporary until I figured out what I really wanted to do with my life, which apparently is nothing. . . . I'm gonna be one of those losers who end up on his deathbed, saying "Where'd my life go?" (1/3/1)

Nate even tries to confront the temporariness of his identity by looking directly into the face of what he fears most: death. At the same time, he acknowledges his "tourist self." Explaining to David why he has suddenly decided to become an active partner in the family business after avoiding that role, he says:

This is what I'm supposed to do. Which is why I've spent so much time running away from it. My whole life, I've been a tourist. Now, I have the chance to do some good instead of just sucking up air. (1/3/1)

Claire

Claire, the third child in the family, was born around fifteen years after her two adult brothers, who are close in age to each other. As a result, the Fishers, like Claire herself, see her as an outsider, as an "extra person" (1/10/2). Claire also expresses

her outsider status in her self-perception as a freak: "It's like I've got a big sign on my head that says 'freak with a dead dad'" (1/2/1). Even her schoolmates see her this way, nicknaming her "Morticia" and "freak" to her face and recognizing her as the one who lives in a funeral home and drives a hearse to school. Claire reinforces this image by isolating herself further from her peers, seeing them as "pretentious drama nerds" (1/6/3) having the "mentality of teenagers" (1/12/1).

Above all, Claire is horrified by the idea of living her life as a typical Fisher. She is afraid of "catching" the death, the silence, and the inertia that shadows her family. She describes this shadow to her school psychologist as sadness or fear, maybe. It's like, ya know, everybody's so scared that they're gonna say the wrong thing 'cause like, ya know, when you bury someone it's like the most sensitive time in a person's life. It's like, my family, they're just so careful. It's like they almost become invisible. (1/12/2)

In addition, Claire is apprehensive about other characteristics of the death-self catching up with her as she grows older, such as becoming a conformist and losing her creativity. When her school psychologist asks her if she is planning to go to college, she answers rebelliously:

Is that the only option? Go to college, get a job so you can be a good consumer until you drop dead of exhaustion? I don't want that. . . . I just want something to matter. Maybe I should wander around the desert and eat peyote and see God. (1/7/1)

Claire's attempts to develop a life-centered self are expressed in three venues: her experiences with men, art, and drugs. First, Claire dates men whom she perceives as exciting, dangerous, and "alive," even though she ends up realizing that they are more representative of death, tragedy, and mental illness (Gabe, Billy). Second, Claire discovers a particular talent and interest in arts that document alternate realities (drawing, photography, and sewing), and she even fantasizes about how wonderful it would have been to live during the Renaissance, a period symbolic of the revival of arts. Third, experimentation with illicit drugs and mushrooms succeeds in eliciting from her traits that she sees as opposite to those she associates with her family: honesty, openness, and creativity. Under the influence of drugs, Claire is presented to the viewer as softer, more loving, and patient toward her mother and brothers, less cynical, and more sensitive and inspired.

Claire likens herself to Nate, to whom she turns in the hope that he will understand her more than her mother and David, whom she sees as her opposites in their death-self inhibitions. She perceptively recognizes her mother's distress ("my mother is just so sad") and her family's dysfunctional nature: "I don't think there was a time that this family was ever happy. . . . I was too young to realize what freaks we were" (1/5/2). She is also the only member of the Fisher clan who recognizes the irony of living so closely with death. After stealing a foot from a corpse, she observes: "I know that stealing a foot is weird, but, hello, living in a house where a foot is available to be stolen is weird" (1/5/2).

Interestingly, Claire’s friends and family appreciate the exact aspects of her life-self that Claire wishes to identify with. Gabe, her boyfriend, tells her that she “can see through walls.” He reassures her of her uniqueness:

Nobody could reprogram you. You’re the most original girl in the school. Come on. Look at this car that you drive. This face that you drive. . . . You know how much guts it takes to be somebody like you? (1/2/1)

THE LIFE-SELF AND THE DEATH-SELF: CENTRAL COMPONENTS

After defining the terms *life-self* and *death-self* and describing the characters who represent these identity-roles, we summarize in Table 1 each of these constructs with the aid of five central components—primary action, symbol, significant self-partner, direction, and primary message—that characterize this type of self in the script. We see these five components as core elements of the self that enable the definition and its maintenance, symbolize it, and typify the transformation that it might experience.

TABLE 1. Life-Self and Death-Self

	Death-Self		Life-Self	
	Ruth	David	Nate	Claire
Primary action	Caring	Sacrifice	Running	Experimentation
Symbol	Flowers	Closet	Bus	Art
Significant self-partner	Nikolai (passionate Russian lover)	Keith (sexy black cop)	Brenda (sexually liberated masseuse, daughter to ex-hippie psychiatrists)	Gabe/Billy (badboys)
Direction	Death to life	Death to life	Life to death to life	Experimenting with life and death
Primary message	You have to care for yourself and not just live through others. You have to “feel” life, not just “speak life.”	You have to face up to who you are privately and publicly—come out of the closet. Stop being a victim.	You cannot run away from death or from yourself. Life and death catch up with you. You cannot develop a self without facing death.	You have to find your own way of expression, be original, and create.

Transitory Movements

To this point, we have presented what we call the life-self and the death-self as distinct and opposite concepts. As suggested earlier, we see this presentation of selves as mirroring the American cultural attitudes toward life and death, a perception that is also epitomized in the unidirectional paths that the members of the Fisher family take in their pursuit of meaning. Specifically, contemporary American culture offers a one-way path for self-development: from destruction to renewal, repression to liberation, the death-self to the life-self.

The Fishers attempt such one-way transformations, only to fail miserably. Ruth and David call upon various techniques to relinquish their death-selves and to embrace life. Nate makes every effort to maintain his life-self by running away from death, even when it physically assaults him with a dangerous brain disorder. Claire aims to maintain her life-self in being a typical teenager, flirting with both life and death in experimental curiosity. The failure of the Fisher family to transform, replace, or even maintain their role-identities (Stryker 1980) brings to the foreground a subversive commentary on the promises of modern society: there is no one-way path, and identity is not synonymous with stability.

Furthermore, the portrayal of the death-self and the life-self and their complementary attempts at finding meaning along their binary paths only serves to break apart the binary itself. If the only path toward a meaningful existence is one that embraces life, then we would expect Ruth's attempts to acquire a life-self to transform her into a happy, liberated, communicative person, and for David to be lighthearted and extroverted once he has come out of the closet. Moreover, the assumption of a unidirectional path toward meaning would lead us to see Nate's escape to Seattle as a permanent one; it does not explain why this life-self is constantly drawn back to his family home in Los Angeles or his subsequent understanding that only by facing death can he have a meaningful life.

Finally, the assumption of a linear path does not explain why the partners they choose in romance seem to catch death from the Fishers and subsequently have trouble maintaining the life-selves that initially attracted the Fishers to them. For instance, the sexy, proudly gay cop Keith, who encourages David to come out and to live during the first season, becomes introverted, aggressive, emotionally troubled, and pedantic in the second season. Likewise, the brave and brutally honest Brenda, Nate's girlfriend, becomes a lying, self-destructive sex addict. The "cool guy at school" Gabe, Claire's boyfriend, becomes a suicidal drug dealer and murderer; finally, the romantic, outspoken Nikolai, Ruth's boyfriend, becomes a stifled, complaining, unexpressive recluse.

What we are left with is a commentary on the self as it waltzes back and forth between the categories of life and death, not fully occupying either one, a transition that endows the self with meaning. Accordingly, we offer the concept of transitory movements, which draws upon the idea of transition—an oscillation or wavering movement between states—rather than transformation, which would imply a marked, radical conversion.

Our concept of the transitory movement avoids an either-or approach, suggesting instead multiple exits and entrances between various spaces of personal identity and an emphasis on the revolving doors of the self. The Fishers do not experience a before and after narrative; instead, they zigzag between points. However, this zigzag narrative does not necessarily include, as Zerubavel's (2004) term suggests, a series of "rise and fall" or "fall and rise movements" (pp. 18–20), but maintains a continuous, level, back-and-forth movement.

Transitory movements are not conceptualized in tenses of past and present identities—in or out of the closet, disillusioned or enlightened, or, in our terms, life-self or death-self—but as something closer to the concept of "alternation" (Travisano 1970). Travisano's concept of alternation tempers the totality implicit in the idea of "conversion" that underlies the literature on religious conversion. Whereas conversion refers to a radical change and an acute acquisition of a new, pervasive identity that directs most of one's interactions and personal choices, alternation describes changes attainable within the existing discourse universe.

While we agree with this logic, we would like to pull away from the assumption central to alternating between an old self and a new self and propose an even more fluid alternative. Our analysis also identifies several ways that the central characters maintain this movement. Ruth enters and exits sites that she identifies as life-related (racetrack, flower shop) or sites of self-improvement, such as the popular therapeutic life-affirmation seminar that she attends ("The Plan"). However, as soon as she exits these sites, Ruth experiences disappointment because of her unsuccessful transformation: her failure to fully internalize a life-self. Consequently, she continues to search for a life-self at other sites and sees her chronic movement from death-self to temporary life-self and back again as a sign of something "faulty" in her "foundation," as expressed in the life-architecture idiom of "The Plan."

David maintains the transitory movement through repeatedly exiting and reentering the closet, especially in numerous moments of epiphany that he experiences while speaking with the ghosts of the corpses he embalms. They urge him to become a life-self, but he immediately returns to his death-self after momentary outings. Examples of this are David's outing of himself to his brother and his momentary show of courage in the face of a rival funerary company, only to reenter the closeted role of deacon at his church; his momentary confidence speaking at a Las Vegas undertakers convention, only to take self-destructive, closeted measures after accidentally being outed; and his brave address to his congregation, only to later step down from his deaconship in defeat.

Nate maintains the transitory movement primarily through running, literally and metaphorically. Nate is not the only one who got away and an avid runner, but he chooses to increase his speed during moments of introspection. In this way, the viewer is exposed to Nate's transition: he leaves one location and is targeted for another, from death to life. However, we never see Nate stopping, but view him constantly in a liminal space that can be likened to the "liminal stage" described by Van Gennep ([1909] 1960) or the "betwixt and between" state described by Turner (1967).

Unlike Van Gennep's concept, Nate's liminality is not temporary on the way to a marked "end point" but is a chronic liminality. Nate achieves his moments of insight while he is in the transitory running state in the form of liminal experiences such as the near-death experience, the out-of-body experience, and after-life communication.

Claire maintains her waltz between life and death through experimenting with persons and pursuits that symbolize life or death or both simultaneously. She is both attracted and repulsed by suitors Gabe and Billy because they represent the borderline state between a sexy, nonconventional, life-centered persona and depressive, suicidal, mentally unstable death characteristics.

The fluidity that we have discussed in the concept of transitory movements may resemble the mutability of postmodernism. However, the transitory movement is neither an endless fluidity that refuses to commit to any particular fixed identity (Gottschalk 1993:353) nor "a dizzying array of possibilities for the self" (Gubrium and Holstein 2000:95), as postmodernism implies. Instead, our concept stresses the chronic movement between two fixed categories (life and death) that endow the self-concept with meaning. In this sense, the fluidity that we describe is more limited than that described in postmodernism.

CONCLUSION

This article aimed to reveal what the sociology of life and death can teach us about the social construction of the self. The popular binary attitude toward life and death has produced two societies that are dichotomous in their approaches to life and death (traditional and modern); two kinds of death (biological and social); and two kinds of selves (life-self and death-self). Not only is the content of these two types of selves different, but different body parts represent them, different cities symbolize them, different cultural artifacts are associated with them, and different role-identities characterize them. These respective dichotomies are accompanied by the moral encouragement to avoid death and to embrace the healthful side of the binary: life.

However, the identity-work of the characters is not so strictly dichotomous. Instead, it is accompanied by anxiety and frustration over their failure to perform a perfect transformation from death to life. As a result, a waltzing movement between stations of life and of death characterizes the characters' selves. Any attempt, imaginary or actual, to occupy the life-position results in a subjective impression of failure.

We stressed this movement between life and death through the concept of transitory movements, which refers to the waltzing movement that characterizes each character in the series. It is important to note that the identity-spaces that we are proposing are not liminal in the same way recognized by Van Gennep ([1909] 1960) and Turner (1967) in their classic texts. For them, liminality is temporary, a life-construct that mediates between the successive stages of "separation" and "incorporation." The assumption at the basis of this "rite of passage" model is optimistic: the agent is assumed to successfully complete each stage and to adopt the new identity. We suggest that transitory movements are not temporary; these movements do not occur on

the way to a new identity. We are referring to a way of life, a more stable structure and not the “anti-structure” implied in Turner’s concept of liminality (1967). In line with Van Gennep and Turner, one might call this a state of chronic liminality. In this sense, transitory movements are daily movements between fixed cultural categories and reflect oscillation (Stroebe and Schut 1999).

What, then, maintains the binary of the life-self and the death-self? What might prevent the adoption of the waltzing self that is described in this article? Here we argue that this binary approach to the self is not coincidental but the product of three dominant Western discourses on self and identity: therapeutic discourse, sexual identity discourse (coming out of the closet), and religious conversion. These three discourses construct the desired self along a parallel dualist axis to the life-death dichotomy. Specifically, they look at the subject along an axis of before and after in which a clear binary movement of the self from a state of being buried, trapped, disillusioned, frightened, and in the closet to a state of being alive, liberated (therapeutic discourse), enlightened (religious conversion), proud, and out of the closet (sociology of the closet).

The first discourse is the therapeutic ethos (popular culture version at least), which we view as the most influential. Built upon the legacy of Freud, the ethos has created an ideal type of self that emphasizes self-improvement, adaptation, growth, agency, reinvention, and entrepreneurship (Rose 1996). These qualities of the ideal self closely accord with Freud’s concept of “eros” and depart from his concept of “thanatos” (Freud [1930] 1962). This discourse also stresses the modern values of self-control, rational thought, reflexivity, and self-care. It sees the aspiration of individuals to be communicative and self-reflexive as well as able to solve conflicts and exude positive energy.

The therapeutic ethos understands a preoccupation with death as a sign of being troubled and of pathology, necessitating psychotherapeutic healing to transfer attention toward life (Illouz 2003; Rose 1996). Even the death of a loved one is framed along the one-directional path of progress toward a new life. Namely, bereavement is seen as “an opportunity for personal growth” (Seale 1998:5–6; Walter 1991:304).

The second discourse that reflects the life-death dichotomy in the social construction of the self is that of sexual identity. Central to this scholarship is the metaphor of the closet, which is used to distinguish persons who have come out—publicly shared and received recognition of their sexual identity—from those who remain in the closet. The closeted self is largely depicted as silently screaming, keeping secrets, feeling trapped, hiding, and denying the “true self” (Turner 1976), and as the victim of sociopolitical repression. The outed self is seen as the binary opposite: liberated, open, and courageously subversive of the sociopolitical order (Floyd and Stein 2002; Risman and Schwartz 1988; Rust 1993).

We offer that a deconstructionist approach to this discourse reveals a logic that can best be described through metaphor. Accordingly, if being in the closet is understood to be the death (metaphorically) or killing of the self (existential), then coming out is viewed as an act of embracing truth, light, power, and life. The binary logic behind

this discourse frames the act of coming out as largely one of progress, discovery, self-acceptance, and recognition (Gagne, Tewksbury, and Mcgaughey 1997). This linear progression from death to life is best encapsulated in the stage-development model, which is dominant in sexuality scholarship (Cass 1979). While recent additions to this scholarship, such as the “constant search” proposed by Rust (1993:72), have offered more fluid models of coming out as a process of switching back and forth between identities (p. 67) rather than a radical transformation or a stepwise progression (p. 53), most of the literature still posits that there is only one way to go: from in to out, from death of the self to life.

The third and final discourse that we identify as supporting the life-death dichotomy in constructing the Western self is that of religious conversion. The self-transformations described here are of rebirth (as suggested by James [1902] 1958). Much of this scholarship follows the developmental model, which focuses on the successive stages of conversion, beginning with early doubts and ending with full integration of the new identity (Lofland and Stark 1965). The conversion literature describes for the most part successful conversions: those that achieve full incorporation of a new self at the end of the process. Once again, the linear process assumes a radical change from death (before conversion) to life (rebirth, enlightenment).

In summary, the three discourses construct a binary approach to the self as either-or, positioned on a one-way track of before and after, in which the former self (death) is transformed into a new self (life). This either-or logic allows one to be classified in one of two oppositional categories of self: the first is healthy, liberated, communicative, happy, and occupied with self-betterment. The second is defined by suffocation, suffering, a preoccupation with death-related issues, and dark ideals. In short, one can be either healthy in mind or mentally ill, just as one can be jailed in a closeted, secretive, repressed identity—sexual or otherwise—or liberated after coming out. Whether through therapy, coming out, or religious conversion, the path leads clearly toward its unidirectional goal: from confinement (a death-self) to transformation (a lively, healthy, liberated life-self).

This analysis has implications for the scholarly inquiry into the relationship between life, death, and the self in the study of everyday life. Although we have developed our argument by analyzing a television text, one can ask, for instance, to what extent life and death are represented in the self-concept of ordinary people? What are the dynamics of life and death in everyday life? Are they dichotomous or transitory movements, as we suggest? If they are transitory, can we identify different types of transitory movements in everyday life? We propose that further symbolic interactionist studies might examine the contribution of internal interactions between cultural categories to self-constitution or to the self-to-self conversations they produce. As this article suggests, such inquiries must include the symbolic interaction that individuals conduct with spaces, sites, body parts, and cultural artifacts associated with life and death.

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NOTES

1. Memento mori is Latin for “Remember your death!” History is rich with such reminders in the form of traditional objects and symbols associated with death, such as the hourglass, sword, and skeleton. The most common appearance of memento mori in Western history was as an intensifier for enjoying the good life in the present. A quick remembrance of death was intended to spur the living to “eat, drink and be merry, for tomorrow you shall die” (Kastenbaum 1989).
2. We refer to the self-concept in line with Turner’s (1976) and Gecas’s (1982) definition. Accordingly, we regard the self as a “Relatively stable, coherent organization of characteristics, attributes, attitude, and sentiments that a person holds about himself or herself” (Charmaz 1991:279).
3. There are several theories that attempt to explain the origin of this tradition. Among the most popular explanations are that such a depth would allow the burial of several coffins in the same plot; that burying the body at a sufficient distance from the ground would protect the living visitors to the cemetery from the smell of decomposing bodies; and, finally, that if not buried deep enough, the dead might crawl out of their graves and haunt the living.
4. The authors would like to express their gratitude to the Web site sixfeetunderfan.org for the detailed episode transcripts published there. These transcripts were extremely helpful to us in analyzing the spoken dialogue. The analysis focuses on the first and second seasons. However, the main themes of the analysis continue into the third and fourth seasons as well.
5. For a detailed description of these methodological stages see especially Strauss 1978:43–48.
6. It is important to note that the association of the life-self with sexuality, liberty, and cursing is a product of the secular, liberal, and post-Freudian discourse rather than the religious discourse of many Americans. Here we thank one of the anonymous reviewers who commented that according to the religious discourse, the Victorian type—the conformist, like Ruth and David, who religiously attends church—would be viewed as a life-self, and the sexual, cursing type would be viewed as a sinful death-self. In addition, Ruth and David both associate what the religious discourse sees as life in terms of the death-self. Specifically, they understand their own respectful behavior as inhibition and view the church as a site of suffocation that constructs them as sinners (adulterer, homosexual). This in turn leads us to assume that they are speaking the secular Western therapeutic discourse (Rose 1996).
7. In this sense the life-self is reminiscent of the shift between the impulsive self and the institutional self proposed by Turner (1976). Turner describes the impulsive self as spontaneous, unrestricted, and loyal to internal criterion. The concept of the institutional self represents society and its institutions as mechanisms of social control that disturb the realization of the true self. Although our concept of the life-self shares some characteristics with the impulsive self, we refrain from the sharp distinction between the self and society implied in Turner’s approach.
8. Numbers in parentheses refer to season/episode/act.

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